

Paper 3: Modern depth study

Overview

The relevant pages of this section specify the content that must be taught for the chosen option.

Students are required to study one modern depth study. All of the content for the option is mandatory.

The depth studies focus on a substantial and coherent short time span and require students to understand the complexity of a society or historical situation and the interplay of different aspects within it. Depending on the depth study chosen, these may include social, economic, political, cultural and military aspects.

The main content is divided into four key topics. These provide a framework for teaching and understanding the option, but should not be taken in isolation from each other. For each depth study, there is some chronological overlap between key topics – this structure helps highlight the complexity and interplay of different aspects within society.

Assessment

Students will be assessed on all four Assessment Objectives. All questions may relate to any content specified in the four key topics.

Questions focusing solely on knowledge and understanding will target causation.

Other questions will target the ability to analyse and evaluate contemporary sources and later interpretations. Students should be aware that interpretations are based on evidence from their period of study. They should be aware of a range of evidence that can be used to reach conclusions. They should study examples of such evidence and consider ways in which it could give rise to and support different interpretations. Students should understand a range of reasons why interpretations may differ. They should be aware that differences based on conclusions drawn from evidence are legitimate and can be explained. They should be able to evaluate given interpretations using their own knowledge of the period.

Option 30: Russia and the Soviet Union, 1917–41

Key topic 1: The revolutions of 1917

1 The growth of opposition to the tsar in early 1917	• Growing discontent among peasants and town workers. • The impact of the First World War: military defeats; economic, political and social effects; the Tsar as commander-in-chief.
2 The February Revolution	• The immediate reasons for the February Revolution: events in Petrograd in February 1917, including strikes and the mutiny in the army. The Tsar's absence and abdication.
3 The Provisional Government	• The establishment of the Provisional Government and the problems it faced, including 'Dual Control' and Soviet Order Number 1. The role of Kerensky. • The weaknesses and failures of the Provisional Government. • The significance of the Kornilov Revolt.
4 The Bolshevik Revolution	• Lenin's return and activities, including the April Theses and the growth in support for the Bolshevik Party. The 'July Days'. • The Bolshevik seizure of power in October 1917. The reasons for their success. The roles of Trotsky and Lenin.

Key topic 2: The Bolsheviks in power, 1917–24

1 Early consolidation of power, 1917–18	• The early Bolshevik decrees of November–December 1917. • The removal of opposition, including the Constituent Assembly and the execution of Tsar Nicholas II and his family. • The reasons for, main terms, and significance of, the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk. Different reactions in Russia to the Treaty.
2 The Civil War, 1918–21	• The reasons for, key events and effects of the Civil War. • The reasons for the Bolshevik victory, including the strengths of the Bolsheviks, role of Trotsky, foreign intervention and the weaknesses of the Whites.
3 Moves towards totalitarianism	• The Red Terror and the role of the Cheka. The Kronstadt Mutiny. • Bolshevik centralisation, including the role of Lenin and the Politburo. Setting up of the USSR.
4 Economic and social change, 1918–24	• Reasons for, and features of, War Communism. Reasons for its unpopularity. • Reasons for, and features of, the New Economic Policy. Different reactions to the NEP. Its effects on the economy, 1921–24. • Social changes, including the impact of Bolshevik policies on women, education and culture.

Key topic 3: Stalin's rise to power and dictatorship, 1924–41

1 The struggle for power, 1924–28	• The strengths and weaknesses of Stalin and his rivals (Trotsky, Kamenev, Zinoviev and Bukharin). • The reasons for the emergence of Stalin as leader of the USSR, including the removal of rivals for the leadership in the years 1924–28.
2 The use of terror in the 1930s	• The reasons for, nature of and consequences of the purges, including the purges of the armed forces. • The work of the secret police (NKVD); the use of, and conditions in, the labour camps. • The reasons for, and the importance of, the show trials of 1936–1938.
3 Propaganda and censorship	• Official culture, socialist realism, control of education and religion. Media censorship. • The new Constitution of 1936.
4 The Cult of Stalin	• The meaning of the Cult of Stalin and reasons for its introduction. • How the Cult of Stalin was achieved.

Key topic 4: Economic and social changes, 1924–41

1 Agriculture and collectivisation	• Stalin's reasons for changes in agriculture, including the problems of the NEP. • The organisation of collectives, mechanisation, widespread opposition and the attack on the kulaks. Famine in Ukraine. • The successes and failures of collectivisation.
2 Changes in industry	• Stalin's motives for rapid industrialisation, including the failings of the NEP. • Gosplan, Five-Year Plans and the Stakhanovite Movement. • The successes and failures of industrialisation.
3 Life in the Soviet Union	• Living and working conditions in towns and the countryside. • The differing experiences of social groups.